

Claude Code for Accounting Research

Module 6 — Seminar: AI, the Production of Knowledge, and
the Academic Research Market

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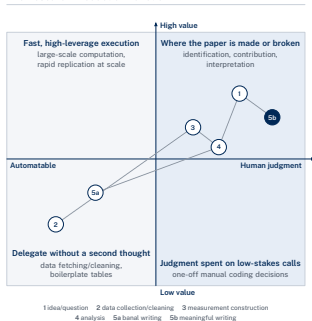
The Week, With a Price Tag

Module	What you built	This week	~2019
2	R&D-intensity panel, SEC FSIDS	80 min lab	RA, ~1 week
3	EDGAR risk-factor pipeline + reusable skill	80 min lab	RA, 2–3 weeks
4	Filtered, verified Compustat funda pull	80 min lab	RA, several days
5	Hardened, rerunnable repo: paper trail, git	~3 hrs	RA, days of audit

That speed-up raises a question that is not technical.

Place Your Dissertation on This Map

The Research Production Function



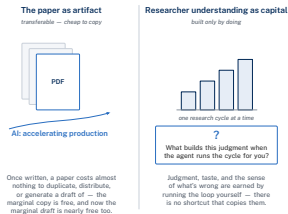
Pipeline stages $\times$ automatable $\leftrightarrow$ human-judgment $\times$ low $\leftrightarrow$ high value.

Do this now, on your own

Place your own dissertation's stages on this map. Don't discuss yet. Block 1 opens with two volunteers defending their placement.

The Artifact and the Capital

Artifact vs. Human Capital



Artifact: transferable, cheap to copy. Capital: built only by doing the work.

The personal audit

Can you discuss it without the LLM? Macnamara et al.: AI takes over the sub-tasks where expertise gets built. Gerlich: higher attainment weakens skill decay but does not eliminate it.

Provenance: Who Is Accountable?

“A computer can never be held accountable.”

— IBM training manual, 1979

Nature's two rules (2023)

1. No LLM will be credited as an author. Authorship carries accountability a model cannot take on.
2. Any use of these tools must be documented

A Retraction, Not a Citation

Retraction case study: labeled as such, never cited as evidence

A 2024 working paper claimed that a randomized rollout of an AI materials-discovery tool raised researcher output 44%

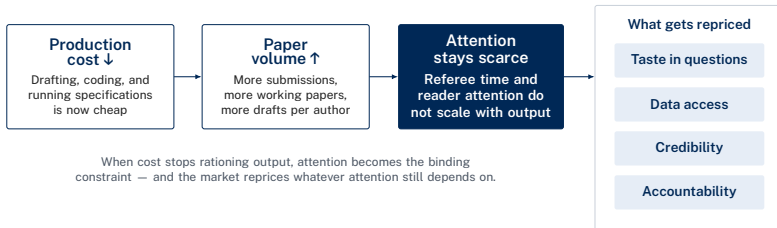
- Circulated to acclaim from prominent economists, then found to be fabricated
- Author severed from MIT; paper withdrawn
- The field's provenance-checking machinery failed *before* AI was writing papers

The open question

Does AI make that machinery stronger (audit trails) or weaker (volume)?

Papers Are the Currency

The Academic Market Repriced



Placement, tenure, prestige, salary all clear through publications. Bloom, Jones, Van Reenen & Webb (2020): ideas are getting harder to find. Lusher, Yang & Carrell (2023): more working papers the same week → worse outcomes for each, not just the weak ones.

Rules of Engagement

- Three blocks, ~30 min each, with a 5-min stretch between
- Each block: 2-min position statements (assigned Module 5) → open discussion → instructor synthesis
- No catastrophizing and no dismissing: pair every provocation with its counterargument
- Memo due one week after today

Block 1 — Knowledge vs. Learning

- If AI produces the artifact, what happens to the learning?
- Opens with your dissertation placement; two volunteers defend theirs
- Which pipeline stages build intuition worth protecting?
- Accounting parallel: AI-assisted audit judgment

Closing question

Is PhD training a production process, or a transformation of the student?

Block 2 — Man vs. Machine

- Does it matter, epistemically or socially, who or what produced a result?
- Two identical extractions, one hand-coded by an RA and one from Claude with an audit trail. Are they equivalent?
- A spotless audit trail can still deliver a wrong estimate
- 10-min segment: when a second model reviews the first model's code, what is verified?

Closing question

Does AI make the field's provenance-checking machinery stronger or weaker?

Block 3 — Returns to Research

- Papers are the currency. What happens when production costs collapse?
- You built the Module 4 pipeline in an 80-minute lab. Suppose every accounting PhD can.
- Scarce candidates: question taste, data access and institutional knowledge, credibility, accountability
- Homogenization: if every referee report passes through the same models, does voice still signal anything?

Closing question

Name one input you believe stays scarce. That answer is the starting point for your memo.

The Memo

“What I will still be paid for in 2036”: one page, due in one week

- Commit to specific components of the research production function that stay human
- Defend with one course reading *and* one experience from the build modules
- Name one concrete investment for your remaining PhD years

Grading

Credit/no-credit on **defended specificity**. An optimist and a pessimist can both earn credit; a vague memo cannot.